



provided Hamilton with the reset he needed. A new race engineer, extensive work behind the scenes to align the car setup with his preferences and a renewed sense of energy seem to be doing the trick.

Hamilton looked a level above everyone else at the Circuit de Catalunya. Powered by Ferrari's aggressive three-stop strategy, the former Mercedes driver stayed hot on the heels of pole-sitter George Russell throughout the first half of the race on a track where drivers struggle to keep the rear tyres in the optimal window because of the high temperatures. A perfectly timed Virtual Safety Car allowed Hamilton to retain the lead with a cheap pit stop, but judging by the pace he demonstrated in the final stint, he would have caught his former teammate and pulled away at the front regardless.

Teammate Charles Leclerc's day was not as rosy. The Monegasque failed to finish the Grand Prix for the second consecutive week, coming soon after signing a new multi-year

deal with the Prancing Horse. Since Hamilton's arrival, Leclerc has been Ferrari's lead driver and had comfortably outperformed his senior teammate. But the tide appears to be turning. The eight-time race winner is already 40 points behind his celebrated colleague and, in his own words, will need a 'perfect' remainder of the season to make up the deficit.

Antonelli also endured a difficult afternoon. His Mercedes engine gave up a few laps from the finish, leaving him pointless for the weekend and allowing Hamilton to cut the gap in the drivers' standings to 41 points. The young Italian still holds a significant advantage, but with Ferrari's regular updates steadily reducing the gap to Mercedes and with the vast majority of the season still ahead, the quest for an unprecedented eighth crown is surely on.

Bouncing back: For Lewis Hamilton, it was a moment of redemption after a first season at Ferrari that left him questioning himself, and others questioning him. AFP



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